

On the Vices of Modernity

Liberty, Power, and the Pretence of Revolution

“You are not living in a system. You are being processed by one — and you have agreed to it, click by click, because every alternative was made to feel like more work.”

Forward

You wake in a rented room of drywall and flat-pack pine. The blue light has not quite left your skull — four hours last night spent scrolling other people’s highlight reels, the feed dripping its small rewards into you like an IV. Breakfast is a sweet slurry in a bottle with PROTEIN across the front. Lunch arrives in a sweating clamshell. By evening you are tired in a way that sleep does not fix, and you call this stability.

Maybe it is. That is the difficulty. It might genuinely be stability, and it might be embalming, and from the inside the two feel almost identical. You are warm. You are fed. You are, by the standard of nearly every human being who has ever lived, astonishingly safe. And still something is wrong, and you cannot name it, and the not-being-able-to-name-it is itself part of what is wrong.

Past generations are supposed to have bled in mines and torn down walls with their hands. You draft a sharp reply and delete it. You cancel a subscription and feel, for a moment, like you have struck a blow. The rulers — if that is even the right word — need no secret police for this. They need only the autoplay. Why post a guard at the door of the cage when the occupant has no intention of looking for the door?

This essay is about that occupant, who is the writer as much as the reader. It is not a call to storm anything. It is an attempt to be honest about why no one is storming — and honest, too, about the possibility that the honest answer is less flattering to the writer than he would like it to be.

The Question, and the Trap Inside It

The familiar argument runs like this. Every age that fails its promises of justice, prosperity, and dignity breeds the conditions for revolt. Ours fails plainly — grotesque inequality, hollowed-out politics, precarity sold as freedom — and yet produces no revolt worth the name. Instead of barricades, timelines. Instead of Molotovs, dopamine. Never has discontent been so wide; never has it been so quiet.

It is a seductive paradox, and it contains a trap. The question “why is nobody revolting?” smuggles in its own answer. It assumes that revolt is the natural, healthy response to a flawed order, and that its absence is therefore a pathology demanding explanation. But that assumption has to be earned, not pocketed. Before blaming the silence on sedation, an honest essay has to consider that the silence might be reasonable.

So this version begins where the original did not: with the strongest case that nothing is wrong at all.

Before the Argument: The Case That Nothing Is Wrong

By almost every material measure, this is the best moment in history to be alive. Extreme poverty has collapsed worldwide within a single lifetime. Violence, war death, and homicide sit near historic lows. Life expectancy, literacy, child survival — all far better than for any prior generation. In the West specifically, even the discontented are housed, fed, treated, and entertained at a level the medieval lord could not have purchased at any price.

If revolt is a response to desperation, perhaps most people simply are not desperate. And perhaps the refusal to revolt is not sedation but arithmetic. Revolutions usually fail. When they succeed, they usually devour their authors and install something worse — the guillotine, the gulag, the year zero. Incremental reform is slow, ugly, and unsatisfying, but it has, over two centuries, delivered the eight-hour day, the franchise, the welfare state, and civil rights. A person who declines the barricade in favour of the ballot box, the union, the lawsuit, and the slow grind of persuasion may not be drugged. They may have done the math.

This is the most serious objection to everything that follows, and it deserves to be met head-on rather than waved past. Here is what I think it leaves out.

The material case is a case about averages and trajectories, and on those terms it is largely true. But it does not touch the subject of this essay, because this essay is not about hunger. It is about meaning. A person can be safe, fed, medicated, and entertained, and still quietly certain that their days are not adding up to anything. The material ledger has no column for that, and its absence from the ledger does not mean the deficit is not real.

There is a second gap. An improvement in the average is fully consistent with a particular group facing a genuinely worse deal than their parents did — worse on housing, worse on the ownership of anything durable, worse on the simple expectation of stability. The young renter is not poor by the standard of 1840. They may still be correct that something specific has been taken from them.

So the objection is right that this is not the eve of a peasant revolt. It is wrong if it concludes that there is therefore nothing to explain. There is something to explain. It is just not hunger.

It is the strange spectacle of a population that is comfortable, aware that it is dissatisfied, and structurally unable to convert that dissatisfaction into anything that changes its situation.

The Vices

What follows is not a conspiracy. There is no committee. The “vices of modernity” are not weapons aimed at a population; they are the ordinary byproducts of an economy optimised, with great ingenuity, for engagement and consumption. They pacify not because anyone designed them to pacify but because a pacified customer is a more profitable one. This is an old observation. Huxley saw the shape of it in 1932: the most durable control is administered through pleasure, not pain. Guy Debord named the spectacle in 1967. Neil Postman warned that we would amuse ourselves into incapacity. Mark Fisher called the resulting condition capitalist realism — the sense that no alternative is even thinkable. This essay inherits all of that. Its only claim to add anything is to be specific about the mechanisms.

Comfort. Revolt has historically been driven by the body — by hunger, by cold, by pain that cannot be ignored. Modernity has largely solved the body’s emergencies for the Western majority. Calories are cheap even where nutrition is poor; rooms are climate-controlled; whatever the craving, something will deliver it within the hour. A body merely satisfied does not march. It orders again, and it naps. This is not a moral failing. It is simply what bodies do when the alarm stops ringing.

The Feed. What earlier ages might have experienced as political consciousness, the feed converts into content. It offers the sensation of revolt — the share, the dunk, the righteous thread — while quietly stripping out the consequence. Anger does not dissipate; it is metabolised. The outrage that might once have organised a meeting is instead converted, frictionlessly, into engagement, which is to say into revenue. This is the feed’s genius: it does not suppress dissent, which would be expensive and visible. It runs dissent through a meter.

Dissent as a Product Line. Consumer culture long ago learned to sell rebellion back to the rebel. The transgressive sneaker, the tattoo, the explicit lyric, the countercultural brand — each is pre-packaged defiance, monetised before it reaches the buyer. When every gesture of refusal is available for purchase, refusal stops being a threat and becomes a market segment. The system does not punish the rebel. It offers him a discount code.

The Privatisation of Pain. Here a careful distinction is needed, because the original essay was unfair. Therapy helps people. Medication, properly used, saves lives, and to sneer at it is both cruel and false. The critique is not of treatment. It is of framing. When anxiety, burnout, and despair are understood *exclusively* as private malfunctions of the individual — to be journaled, breathed, and medicated away — then their structural causes become invisible and politically

inert. A generation taught to read its own exhaustion as a personal deficiency will optimise its sleep hygiene and never once look up at the conditions producing the exhaustion. The problem is not the yoga mat. The problem is the yoga mat as the *only* offered response.

Spectacle. Debord's insight has only sharpened: the representation of a thing displaces the thing. Protest itself is now substantially a genre of content, measured in reach rather than in outcome. The crowd increasingly wants the *image* of dissent — the postable clip, the aesthetic of resistance — because the image is achievable and the outcome is not. Spectacle cannot dismantle power. It can only photograph itself in front of it.

The Void of Meaning

Earlier generations could draw on shared narratives larger than themselves — faith, nation, lineage, a sense of standing somewhere in a story that began before them and would continue after. Modernity has thinned all of these. Transcendence has receded with religious practice; national belonging is, for many, framed as faintly shameful; history is increasingly taught as an indictment rather than an inheritance. None of these shifts is simply a loss — each corrected real cruelties, and a clear-eyed essay should say so. But the cumulative effect is a population with fewer and fewer frames in which a single life acquires significance beyond itself.

Frankl's line is the relevant one: "When a person cannot find a deep sense of meaning, they distract themselves with pleasure." He meant it as a clinical observation, not a slogan, and as a clinical observation it scales unnervingly well. An entire culture that cannot locate meaning will, predictably, reach for distraction — and modernity supplies distraction at a volume and quality no prior age could match.

Thoreau's "quiet desperation" was written about men who at least had cabins to build and woods to walk. The modern variant is quieter still, because it is comfortable, and comfort removes the obvious enemy. There is no overseer to resent. There is only a low, ambient sense that the days are passing through you rather than accumulating into anything. That is the void: not agony, but the slow oxidation of significance.

The System as Organism, Not Conspiracy

It is tempting to personify all of this — to speak of an "elite" who have skilfully redirected the public's anger, who designed the cage and locked the door. The original essay reached, more than once, for that language. It should be resisted, because it is both false and, oddly, too comforting.

There is no redirection because there is no one redirecting. What there is, instead, is selection. Millions of actors — firms, politicians, platforms, institutions — each pursuing their own incentives, and an environment that quietly rewards whatever arrangements perpetuate themselves and culls whatever does not. Over time this produces an order that *behaves* as if it were designed for self-preservation, for the same reason a body behaves as if designed: not because a designer sat down with a blueprint, but because the things that survive are, by definition, the things good at surviving.

This is a more unsettling picture than conspiracy, not a softer one. A conspiracy has members; members can be exposed, prosecuted, replaced. A self-reproducing order has no headquarters to raid. When anger turns horizontal — faction against faction, neighbour against neighbour, rather than upward against structural power — it is not because a hand turned it. It is because horizontal targets are simply nearer, more vivid, and emotionally cheaper. The immigrant down the road has a face. “The structure of asset ownership” does not. Rage, like water, runs to the lowest and closest point. No one has to dig the channel.

This matters for what can be hoped. If the problem were a cabal, the solution would be exposure. Because the problem is a set of incentives, the only thing that changes it is changing the incentives — which is slow, unglamorous, and resistant to the very urgency that revolt supplies.

The Economic Architecture of Discontent

The discontent has a material spine, and it should be described precisely rather than luridly.

Over the past two decades, asset prices have risen far faster than wages. Years of cheap money inflated the value of what the already-wealthy owned — equities, and above all property — while the income of those who live by working rose slowly or not at all in real terms. Housing, once the ordinary route to security, has in many cities become a function of when you were born and what your parents owned. And in many Western tax systems, income from labour is taxed more heavily than income from capital — the return on already having money. Effort is taxed harder than ownership.

None of this requires a villain. It is the outcome of decades of unremarkable decisions, each individually defensible. But the cumulative result is a society in which a large majority works under conditions of rising precarity while a small minority compounds wealth and the influence that travels with it. That imbalance is the fuel. The vices described above are the reason the fuel does not catch.

Technology and the Price of Labour

The gap is likely to widen, because the value of human labour is now under direct technological pressure. As artificial intelligence and robotics absorb whole categories of work, the bargaining power of the worker — already weak — erodes further. Some form of broad income support may become not an ideological choice but an administrative necessity, simply to maintain demand and order: an AI levy, a sovereign wealth dividend, something.

But notice what such a measure would actually be. It would be the comfort mechanism, extended. A population paid to be quiet is more comfortable than a population left to starve, and also more thoroughly removed from any leverage over its own conditions. The displaced worker who receives a transfer has been kept alive and, in the same motion, made politically weightless. Whether that is humane provision or final pacification is, again, a question the material ledger cannot answer.

The Pattern of Contained Revolt

History suggests the contained outcome is the likely one. In Britain, organised armed insurrection effectively ended at Culloden; afterwards the clan structures that made it possible were dismantled, and dissent was channelled into safer forms — the union, the petition, the party. The two centuries since produced strikes, riots, and campaigns in abundance — the Poll Tax riots of 1990, the riots of 2011 — and the United States its own litany — Watts in 1965, Detroit in 1967, Kent State in 1970, the Capitol in 2021. The pattern holds across all of them: fire without foundation, rage that scorches the surface and leaves the structure untouched.

The same machine has survived two world wars, the loss of empires, the abandonment of the gold standard, the migration of reserve currencies, repeated financial crises, and a global pandemic. Each shock is absorbed; the order mutates and reconstitutes. It is reasonable to expect it would absorb the next one too — and reasonable to expect that if unrest does return, it will arrive horizontally, pleb against pleb, while the structure is observed from a safe distance and a comfortable height.

What Would Prove This Essay Wrong

A theory that explains everything explains nothing. If the absence of revolt confirms the thesis, and the presence of revolt is dismissed as “misdirected,” then the thesis is not an argument; it is a mood that cannot lose. The original essay had exactly that flaw. This version should not, so it owes the reader a statement of its own failure conditions.

This essay is wrong if, within the next decade or two, a movement targets structural or economic power *vertically* and produces durable change — a real shift in how ownership, taxation, or housing work — rather than dissipating into spectacle or rotating one governing party for another. It is wrong if measured meaning and belonging recover on their own, without any change in material conditions, which would suggest the “void” was overstated. And it is wrong if a genuine external shock — a severe enough economic rupture — is met not with horizontal blame but with coherent, vertical, organised demand.

What the essay actually predicts is narrower and, I think, testable. It predicts that discontent will continue to express itself horizontally, faction against faction, and symbolically, online, rather than vertically and materially. It predicts that parties will keep rotating through office without the trajectory of ordinary life changing. It predicts that the next disruptive political figure, of whatever stripe, will function less as a turning point than as a lightning rod — absorbing rage, discharging it, and leaving the architecture standing.

And it makes one further claim, which is the real conclusion. The sedation is probably not permanent, because it is not free. It rests on comfort, and comfort rests on a particular and contingent set of supports: cheap credit, cheap energy, cheap and abundant distraction, and a labour market that still needs human beings. Remove any one of those and the anaesthetic thins. The genuine question of our age, then, is not whether discontent returns. Comfort is contingent, and contingent things end. The question is whether, when discontent returns, it will have learned to find any target at all — other than the neighbour.

Closing Thought

Those who benefit most from the present order would be unwise to read its stability as consent. It is not consent. It is anaesthesia, and anaesthesia is a state that depends entirely on the continued supply of the drug.

Whether modernity has genuinely extinguished the human instinct to rise against extreme imbalance, or merely postponed it behind a wall of comfort that the next crisis will breach, is not something this essay can settle — and it would be dishonest to pretend otherwise. But of the two possibilities, history offers very little support for the first. It has watched a great many orders call themselves eternal. It has outlived all of them.